communities; the concept was summed up in 2004 in a key paper led by American ecologist Mathew Leibold.

The idea of metacommunities is linked to that of metapopulations. While studies of metapopulations examine the different patches where populations of the same species coexist, in metacommunity theory the different patches consist of entire communities that include a number of interacting species.



Mountain goats in Colorado live in a metacommunity of species in a mountain range—the Rocky Mountains—but within a population of goats on one single peak.

What is a metacommunity?

Metacommunities are essentially groups or sets of communities. The communities making up a metacommunity are separated in space, but they are not completely isolated and independent. They interact as various species move between them. For example, a metacommunity might consist of a set of separate forest communities, spread across a region. The various species within each patch of forest habitat interact as an independent